

Anatomy of Anxiety: One Formula, Two Levers

Anxiety = Importance × Uncertainty

$$\text{Anxiety} = \text{Importance} \times \text{Uncertainty}$$

Multiplication, not addition — zero either term and the anxiety goes to zero. Which means two independent places to act

Lever 1: Lower the uncertainty

Not eliminate it — raise your tolerance for it

- **Break the big question into small ones**

"What do I do about the next 20 years" is 100% uncertain; "which three things in six months is this income you fear losing, or the identity? The two have completely different

- **Write the worst case down first**

Uncertain bad becomes certain bad. Certain bad is easier to handle than uncertain good. When "grades to university to job" is itself breaking, grades lose weight automatically

- **Control your information intake**

Read about AI once a week on purpose, instead of being shelled by notifications daily. In an era of structural unemployment, being laid off is a wave, not a verdict on you

- **Practise attention in a relaxed state**

Anxiety narrows vision. Walking and cooking beat doomscrolling for good ideas. If you live in it, the price is irrelevant to your day — unless you actually intend to se

Lever 2: Lower the importance

The more subversive one — much of it matters less than you assume

- **Work**

- **Your child's grades**

- **Face**

- **House prices**

Audit your anxiety list: does this actually matter, or am I hostage to social inertia?

Put one down, and the anxiety drops by one